

Teaching Life Sciences in the Age of AI

Professional Learning for Middle & High School Teachers in the Life Sciences

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 24, 2026 | **10:00 A.M.–3:30 P.M.** | UVA Student Health and Wellness, 550 Brandon Avenue

Workshop Speakers



Barry Condron
Professor, Biology



Christopher Deppmann
Professor, Biology



Natasha Heny
Professor, Teacher Education



Jennifer Maeng
Associate Professor, Education Research



Matthew Pryal
Assistant Professor, Astronomy



Paul Torrey
Assistant Professor, Astronomy; CosmicAI Institute Astro Lead

PART 1 · MORNING

AI in Biology: Research & Practice

Workshop Resources
bit.ly/BIORESOURCES

10:00–10:15	**Welcome & Setting the Stage** Lisa Woolfork, Natasha Heny
10:15–10:35	**Crowdsourcing: AI in Our Practice** Natasha Heny Share a way you are using AI, a concern you have about AI in your practice, and how you see AI impacting life science research and careers.
10:40–11:10	**Fast Tools, Slow Thinking: Raising the Ceiling on What We Teach** Christopher Deppmann AI now lets one teacher build in weeks what used to take a publisher years, and lets us see how every student is reasoning before they walk into class. I'll show what that looks like in practice, including the student who talks a good game but never did the reading, and why the real job is protecting the slow thinking these tools make it easy to skip.
11:10–11:20	***Break***
11:20–11:50	**AI in Biology: a Curse and a Gift** Barry Condron In this talk, we explore how AI is revolutionizing neuroscience by helping researchers better understand brain circuits and behavior. We also examine the potential risks of relying on AI, particularly its implications for learning, critical thinking, and cognitive health.
11:50–12:20	**Q&A with Barry Condron & Christopher Deppmann** Matt Pryal What surprised you about how AI is used in research and teaching? What skills will students need for science careers shaped by AI? Where should humans stay "in the loop"? What does this mean for middle and high school classrooms?

12:20–12:35	**Introducing the Afternoon Workshops** **Matt Pryal** A preview of the four interactive workshops. Rank your interest; we will post the afternoon schedule during lunch—each person will attend two. Resources for all workshops will be available to everyone. bit.ly/AIAFTERNOON
12:35–1:20	***Lunch*** *Workshops begin at 1:25–check the workshop assignments for room #s*

PART 2 · AFTERNOON

Bringing AI into Your Classroom

1:25–2:10	**Workshop Rotation 1** Check the Workshop Assignments to find your room
2:10–2:15	***Transition***
2:15–3:00	**Workshop Rotation 2** Check the Workshop Assignments to find your room
3:00–3:05	***Transition***
3:05–3:25	**Sharing & Takeaways** Return to the main room. What did you create? What will you try with your students? What are your biggest take aways from today?
3:25–3:30	**Feedback & Closing**

Workshop Options

1 Ensuring *Learning* in the Age of AI: Designing More Secure Assessments

Led by Matthew Pryal | Room: 100 A

Exploring strategies to support genuine learning via assessments, while minimizing additional burden on instructors.

2 Using AI to Differentiate Science Activities

Led by Natasha Heny | Room: Conference Room 208

Using AI to support differentiation, including vocabulary development and writing scaffolds.

3 Creating and Interpreting Data Visualizations

Led by Paul Torrey | Room: 101B

Using AI to support instruction on creating ad interpreting graphs, plots, and data.

4 AI for Planning Scientific Investigations

Led by Jennifer Maeng | Room: Conference Room 317

Using AI for instructional planning of scientific investigations.

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